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Chainlink

Chainlink, $LINK
Executive Summary

Pitch Executive Summary
11/18/2025

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Pitch Summary	
Rating	Undervalued
Current Price	Data
Price Target	$25.00
Action Recommended	Buy
Recommended Size	3 ETH
Native Staking	Yes

Key Statistics	
Network	Ethereum
Token Standard	ERC-677 / ERC20
Category	Oracle
Subcategory	Proof of reserves, tokenization
Circulating Market Cap ($M)	$9,387,141,157
Fully Diluted Market Cap ($M)	$13,470,820,915
52 Week Price Range	$10.19 - $30.41
24-Hour Trading Volume	$562M
Total Treasury Holding	$10.8M
Weekly Protocol Fees (est.)	~$98,039.50

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Category Overview & Thesis

Chainlink is the industry-standard oracle and interoperability platform that powers decentralized finance (DeFi) and is rapidly becoming the foundational infrastructure for onchain capital markets. As the adoption of stablecoins, real-world assets (RWA), and onchain data increases worldwide, Chainlink is positioned to benefit from this growth.

Traditional finance leaders including Swift, Euroclear, J.P. Morgan, Mastercard, UBS, Fidelity, and major banks are partnering with Chainlink to facilitate the tokenization and movement of billions in assets. Chainlink delivers all the core infrastructure institutions need to operate onchain: secure data, cross-chain operability, offchain compute, and compliance tooling. This makes Chainlink the only comprehensive solution capable of supporting production-grade tokenized finance.

Project Overview

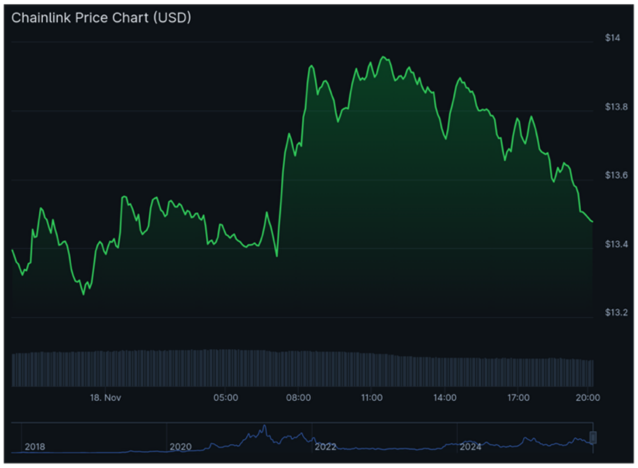
Chainlink sits at the intersection of multiple, fast growing markets

1. Onchain finance and DeFi infrastructure
2. Cross-chain interoperability and messaging (CCIP)
3. Real world asset (RWA) tokenization and onchain capital markets

Project Thesis

With active support and participation from both crypto natives and institutional powerhouses, Chainlink seems poised to solve many of the biggest barriers to blockchain adoption. It's positioning as the dominant oracle in the space makes it invaluable to the daily functioning of the ecosystem. Chainlink as a protocol is here to stay, and its importance looks destined to grow with ($LINK being a main beneficiary of that growth).

There is reason to believe $LINK is undervalued. Despite Chainlink's dominant market position, accelerating enterprise adoption, and growing fee capture mechanisms, the token is down nearly 50% after reaching $30 in late 2024. Recent macroeconomic conditions have been unfavorable, however they don't conflict with Chainlink's future – onchain capital markets. $LINK has been supported multiple times during a volatile year for crypto: at ~$10 in April, and at ~$11 in June. $LINK offers asymmetric upside as the core asset securing and monetizing the world's emerging onchain financial system.



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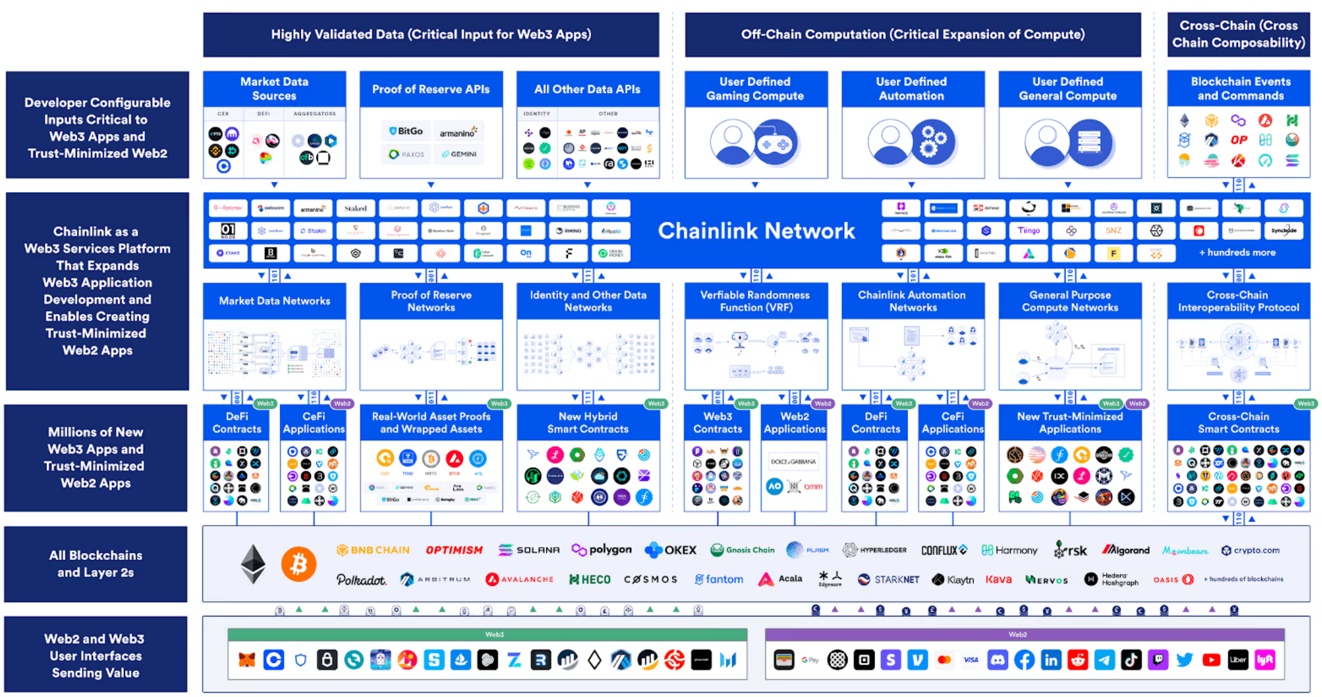
Executive Summary

General Background on Protocol

Chainlink is a decentralized oracle and interoperability platform that enables smart contracts to securely access real-world data, offchain computation, and cross-chain communication. Founded in 2017 by Sergey Nazerov and Steve Ellis, Chainlink emerged in response to a fundamental limitation of smart contracts: blockchains cannot natively interact with external systems. Without a secure bridge for data and messages, blockchains are isolated and incapable of solving institutional demands. Chainlink created a robust solution, building a decentralized network of oracle nodes to deliver tamper-proof data to blockchains. This crucial infrastructure enables lending, derivatives, stablecoins, and tokenized assets.

Over time, Chainlink has grown in the industry-standard oracle platform across multiple blockchains. Over $100 billion in value is secured by the network, and the platform is foundational for many dApps. Since its launch, Chainlink has expanded beyond just offchain data into a full stack platform offering cross-chain interoperability (CCIP), automation, verifiable randomness (VRF), offchain compute, proof of reserves, compliance tooling, and connectivity to traditional financial systems. This broader platform vision is designed to support daily onchain use cases spanning both decentralized and traditional finance.



Macro Factors Impacting Protocol

Factors surrounding blockchain infrastructure has shifted decisively towards institutional adoption, notably seen with the passing of the GENIUS Act in July '25. This landmark law established a regulatory framework for stablecoins, and created rules for issuers, reserves, and consumer protection. Global financial markets are now paying more attention to blockchain technology, and the advantages it proposes - real-time settlement, programmable assets, and transparent collateral systems. As the regulatory foundation strengthens, large institutions will rapidly integrate tokenization into their long-term infrastructure roadmaps. This is a multi-year tailwind for blockchain middleware platforms such as Chainlink.

One of the largest macro tailwinds is the continued adoption of stablecoins[and tokenized RWAs. This decade has seen the total stablecoin supply increase by 1268.8% (see figure below). Stablecoins have become a global payment and settlement instrument with rising daily transaction volumes. Major asset managers, banks, and regulators increasingly view tokenization as inevitable due to its efficiency improvements. Trillions in assets are migrating to blockchain-based infrastructure, and they need Chainlink to enables that transfer.

Another narrative garnering more attention in recent months and mentioned heavily at the 2025 SmartCon hosted by Chainlink, is the relationship between public and private blockchains due to more banks creating their own blockchains. Institutions are in the process of all building out their own environments to manage settlement, and secure interoperability is essential for a global system. Chainlink's cross chain interoperability and messaging (CCIP) has gained traction because it is designed to meet these challenges.

The Team

The origins of Chainlink started before the actual founding of the protocol. Before Chainlink there was SmartContract.com, a startup founded by future Chainlink founders Sergey Nazarov and Steve Ellis in 2014. Because of their oracle problem, Nazarov, Steve Ellis, and Ari Juels got together in 2017 to invent the protocol Chainlink. Chainlink allowed the goal of SmartContrct.com to come true because it allowed smart contracts to access off-chain data on-chain.

Ari Juels was brought in due to his technical expertise. As a well-known cryptographer, Juels was exactly what Nazarov and Ellis needed. The two cofounders of SmartContract.com had a long tenured relationship both personal and professional prior to the launch of Chainlink. It is reported that Nazarov and Ellis met during their time at NYU as they both attended at the same time but that is not confirmed. If not, they likely met professionally as they were both heavily involved in the blockchain space early on. There is also no confirmation for how they initially met and brought in Ari Juels for Chainlink, but it is likely they collaborated on technical research for the initial project due to Juels technical expertise.

Today Chainlink has grown into a major organization. Chainlink Labs is the LLC company behind Chainlink's protocol, and the core of leadership still consists of the three founders. The overall team, however, is very multilayered with many different teams including a large engineering team, research team, business team, etc. With over 600 employees total today, Chainlink had been built up from an early on-chain protocol startup, to being the most important protocol in the decentralized oracle market today. And with the continued need for data to be on-chain with the development in blockchain complexity. The team will likely grow much larger in the future

Roadmap

The Chainlink protocol has been on a healthy protocol trajectory since its development in 2017 with consistent large milestone successes along the way. Their initial vision for a roadmap early on was to set out and solve the "oracle problem" that smart contracts had at that time. They wanted to create a network that was secure and could allow smart contracts to connect and access real-world data. One of the biggest challenges they faced early on was how they were going to have the data computed off chain before delivering it on chain. It is not possible for now to have all this data computed on chain so for its use on chain it needs to be computed off chain and then loaded on chain. This was the biggest early on challenge for Chainlink and it was solved using computing nodes to fetch and compute actual real word data off chain and then cryptographically deliver verified results on chain. This allowed smart contracts to use complex off-chain data on-chain whilst still maintaining security.

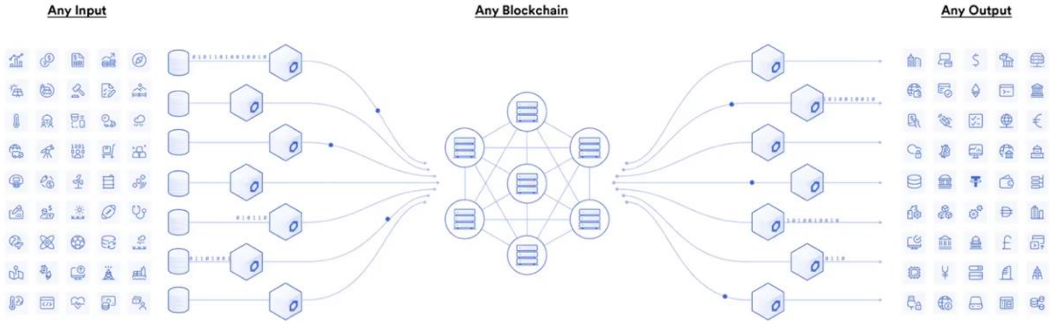
One of their most important milestones was in 2019. In May they launched the Chainlink mainnet on the Ethereum network which marked a major milestone in decentralized oracle technology. This launch marked the first decentralized oracle network with actual incentive potential and promise for future economic gain. It was the first network that had multiple independent nodes and cryptographic promises. Soon after the launch, Chainlink became the largest oracle network provider on the market and became the default protocol for DeFi apps to calculate pricing data. This launch was a foundation for a lot of Chainlink's future successes such as its staking functions, automations, and many more important successful metrics all were made possible from this launch.

In 2020, Chainlink launched Chainlink VRF known as verifiable random function. It served as the first decentralized random generator in Web3, which became a key infrastructure for many projects surrounding gaming, NFTs, and raffling systems. VRF is used by hundreds of protocols today. In 2021 and 2022 they launched Proof of Reserve and Chainlink Automation. These enabled collateral verification through stablecoins and smart contract execution. This was a pivotal time for the company as it broadened their role within DeFi and integrating within larger institutions. In 2023 they had arguably their biggest launch with the launch of the cross-chain interoperability protocol (CCIP). This became the standard for messaging and transferring tokens securely. The protocol has been adopted by large scale organizations such as SWIFT, ANZ, etc.

Specifics on What Protocol Does – Justin

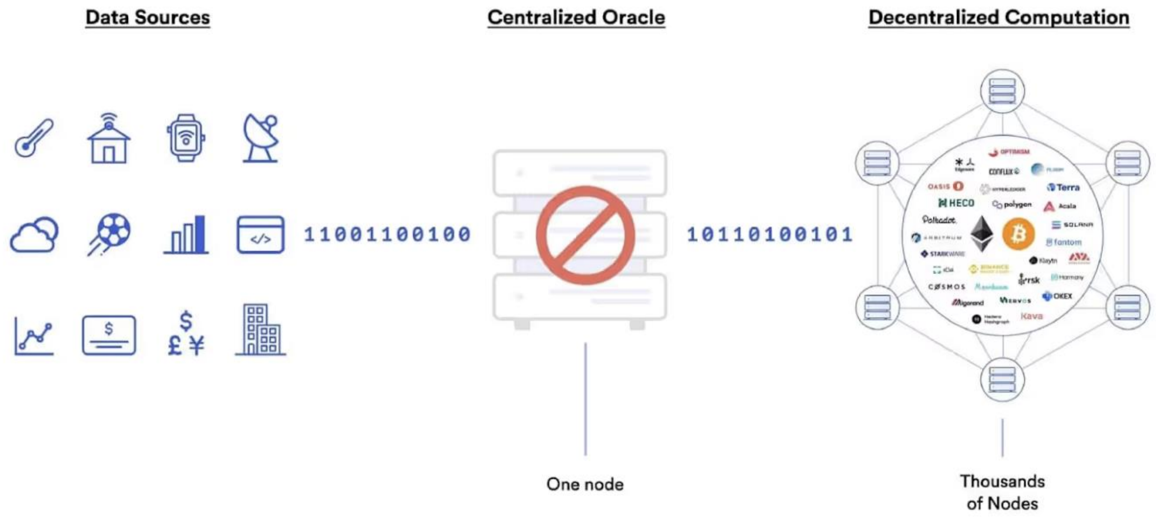
Smart contract data

At the core of what Chainlink provides, they provide secure decentralized data to smart contracts. The networks it has, using decentralized oracles, retain data from off-chain sources to compute it and deliver the results on-chain. This allows smart contracts to safely use external real-world data while remaining decentralized and avoiding being tied with any centralized data resources.



Blockchain oracles connect blockchains to inputs and outputs in the real world

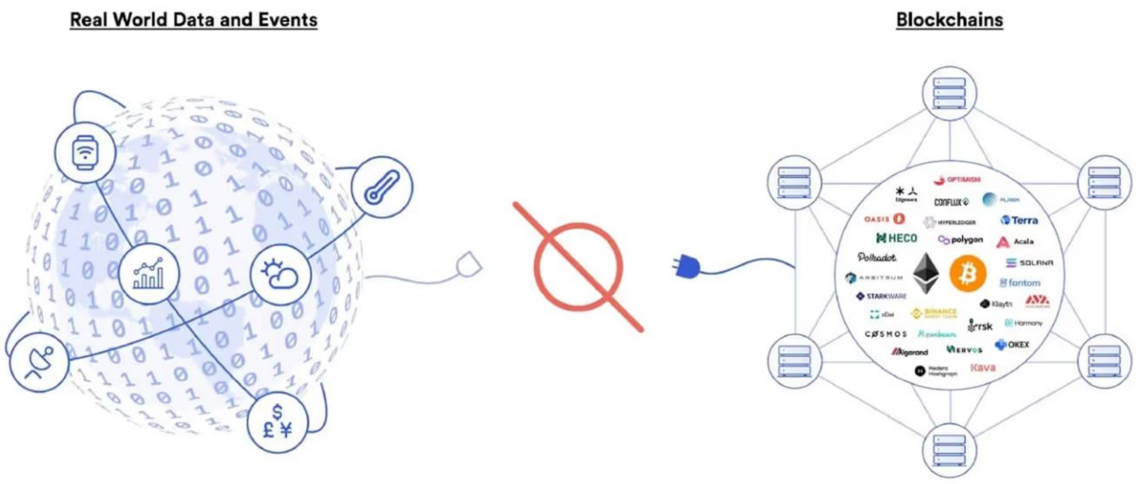
Cross Chain Interoperability Protocol (CCIP)
This Chainlink protocol enables cross-chain communications between blockchain's securely while still being programmable. There are many use cases for this protocol, a few examples are sending data chain to chain, transferring tokens between blockchains, etc. All the use cases for this are not static, they can still be altered or programmed after cross-chain communication has happened. This protocol is backed by Chainlink's oracle network and risk management which provides security and trust for blockchain's to utilize CCIP.



Centralized oracles are a single point of failure

Proof of Reserve
This protocol allows for on-chain verification of off-chain or cross chain asset reserves. What this does is eliminate the problem of on-chain tokens needing collateral to be off-chain which does not allow smart contracts to verify security. This creates an abundance of risks such as risk management or undercollaterization. With Proof of Reserve however, using independent oracle nodes and cryptographic data, it deleivers reserve information on-chain that smart contracts can immediately enforce. These overall builds confidence, lowers risk, and adds to the infastructure that Chainlinks provides and enforces its spot as the leading infastructure in DeFi and traditional finance.

Decentralized Automation
Chainlink's automation system allows uses off-chain conditions and timing to execute automated actions securely. The protocol's oracle nodes are constantly monitoring off-chain events and monitoring the conditions for specific events. When conditions such as price or time are in line, certain on-chain functions will be triggered. This eliminates manual intervention and allows for precision timing while maintaining decentralization and security.



Blockchains cannot connect to real-world data and events on their own

General Auditing Background for Protocol

Chainlink has established itself as one the most trusted networks in the industry through years of rigorous community led auditing, decentralized infrastructure design, and recently accreditation in standards set out by American Institute of Certified Public Accountants (AICPA). Being the first in industry to achieve such standards, Chainlink is trusted to secure the major share of digitized assets, supported DeFi protocols such as Aave, GMX, Ether.fi, Pendle (an asset held by Oregon Blockchain Group), Compound, upon many more. And this isn't mentioned the interest of traditional finance, who will appreciate Chainlink's leanings towards institutional compliance.

Protocol Versus Competitors

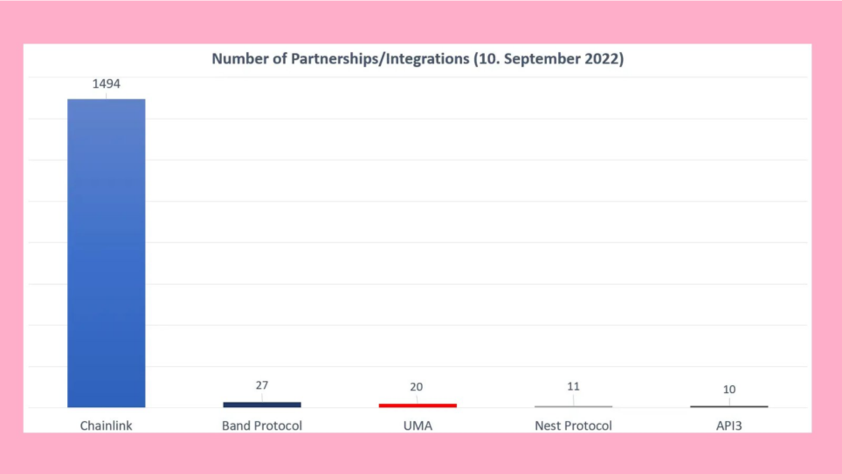
Chainlink's biggest oracle network competitor is the Pyth network. Pyth offers a lot of the same framework as Chainlink but with different architecture behind it. Chainlink uses a pull-based architecture as opposed to Pyth's push-based architecture meaning that within Chainlink's protocol, smart contracts ask for data, which is then fetched through API's externally. With Pyth's push-based architecture, publishers push their data directly onto the protocol. All the data is collected off chain and then broadcasted to supporting chains. Which essentially makes the protocol a decentralized network of publishers, as opposed to independent oracle operators like Chainlink. The key difference comes from where the data comes from. Pyth sources its data from active locations in the market, such as firms and exchanges to allow accurate market pricing, while Chainlink's data comes from independent node operators.

API3 is another key competitor to Chainlink with a completely different "first party oracle" model. This cuts out third-party node operators by having data providers run their own oracle nodes directly. This system is coined as "airnodes," launched in 2020. This system of directly running oracle nodes heavily reduces decentralization to the oracle network and limits the integration level as comparison to a protocol like Chainlink's.

Band is another key competitor in the space launching in 2019 with their own oracle network focusing on cross-chain data. The protocol operates on BandChain which is it's own blockchain built using Cosmos SDK which is a blockchain framework for pre-built modules. The motive for the protocol was to fetch and deliver data through validators at the fastest rate with the lowest fees. Major DeFi protocols have stuck to Chainlink over protocols like Band due to the scale that Band is tied to due to its integration with smaller chains. Between budget issues and struggles to find high level data sourcing, Chainlink operates at a much bigger and more industrial level than Band for the recent past and foreseeable future.

What Chainlink has as an advantage over all of its largest competitors is its proven effects at a scale much larger than the rest. Chainlink has hundreds of blockchains supported, millions of verified oracle deliveries, hundreds of partners sourcing data, and proven security at an industry level standard. While operating for AAVE, stablecoin reserves, and billions in DeFi overall, plus all of their other partnerships, they have had zero large scale mistakes. Allowing their partners to trust the protocol for present and future use.

Protocol Go To Market Strategy Versus Competitors



Chainlink had a switch in their marketing strategy about three years into the development of the protocol that combined with their original mission to allow them to create network effects that none of their competitors have been able to rival from 2017 to about the start of Covid-19 in 2020, Chainlink focused heavily on developers that were developing on Ethereum and partnered with DeFi protocols as a main point of interest with protocols like AAVE, Compound, Synthetix, etc. They had a very large presence in hackathons as data integration was very useful and were overall very developer first.

Around 2020, they started to target more traditional finance, companies like SWIFT, Google, AWS, etc. They started to help these enterprises connect their existing systems to blockchains securely and solve the enterprises problems of not wanting to connect to blockchains individually. The other listed competitor protocols have had much more narrow-minded approaches in their marketing strategies, such as Band with cosmos for example or API3 with first party providers, but Chainlink has made itself the default infrastructure for both decentralized and traditional financial institutions for cross chain oracle provider.

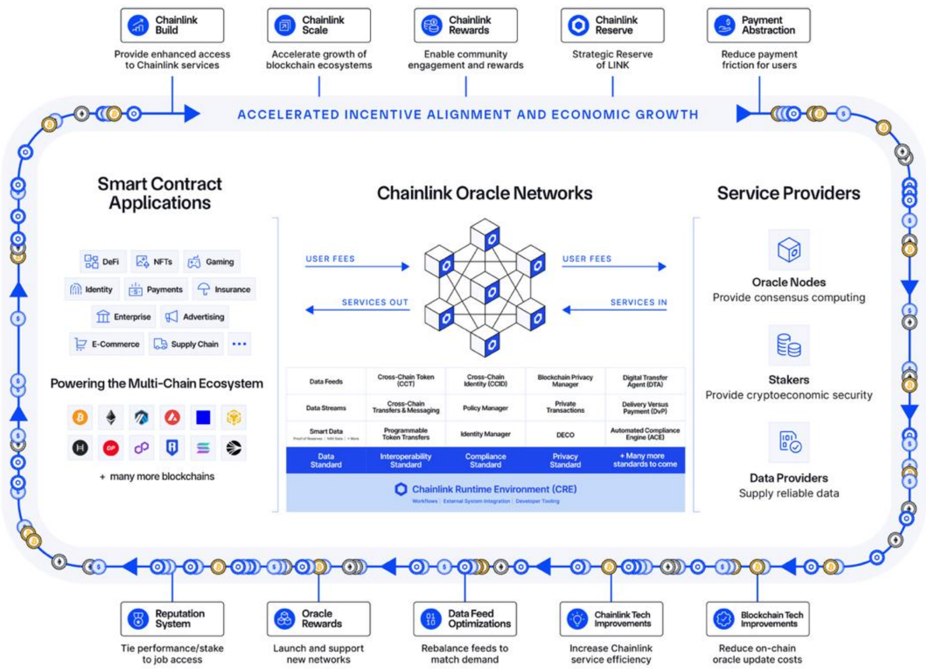
Protocol	Price, USD	Market Cap, USD	Founded
Chainlink	$13.28	$9.25B	2017
Pyth	$0.085	$490.1M	2021
Band	$0.41	$68.4M	2017
API3	$0.56	$48.5M	2020

So as competitors remain niche and useful for specific cross chain interoperability instances, Chainlink remains the standard go-to with their proven track record of scale and security.

How Token Extracts Value

The $LINK token sits at the center of each economic interaction occurring on the Chainlink Network. All Chainlink services generate fees, and whether users pay in $LINK or another asset, payment abstraction converts those fees into $LINK and deposits them into the Chainlink Reserve. This converts both onchain usage and enterprise offchain revenue into consistent, recurring demand for $LINK. As more applications, blockchains, and institutions rely on Chainlink's data feeds, CCIP interoperability, automation, and compliance tools, the total fee volume increases. That fee volume is economically meaningful because it must ultimately be paid or converted into LINK, creating a continuous demand cycle tied directly to real network usage, not simply speculation or attention.

At the same time, LINK is a productive asset: node operators and community members stake LINK to secure services, earn rewards, and signal trustworthiness. Staking creates an economic safeguard, where if a service provider fails to meet performance requirements, their staked LINK can be slashed. Because Chainlink's security model is *super-linear*, incremental stake and additional nodes increase the network's economic security at a faster rate than the stake that is added. This means higher usage results in higher fees, creating increased demand for staking, which leads to greater economic security and lowering average cost for users. In this virtuous cycle, LINK functions both as *collateral securing the network* and as *the asset through which the network captures value*. As the Chainlink ecosystem expands across DeFi and institutional tokenized finance, LINK becomes the primary beneficiary of growing service demand, rising fee pools, and increasing security requirements, further allowing the token to extract value from all aspects of Chainlink's infrastructure layer.



Tokenomics & Analysis

Chainlink's tokenomics have evolved under the Economics 2.0 initiative to achieve long-term financial sustainability across the ecosystem's service providers—node operators, coordinators, and stakers. A critical pillar of this framework is the Chainlink Reserve, an onchain, time-locked treasury that accumulates LINK using both on-chain service fees and off-chain enterprise revenue. Major financial institutions integrating Chainlink infrastructure often pay off-chain in fiat or stablecoins; these payments are now systematically converted to LINK and routed into the Reserve. Early Reserve inflows already exceed $1M of accumulated LINK, with expectations of steady growth as tokenization deployments scale and enterprise usage increases. The Reserve acts as a strategic balance-sheet asset for the protocol, reducing long-term reliance on token emissions and anchoring sustainable network economics.

The circulating supply of LINK currently stands at ~697M tokens, with a fixed total and maximum supply of 1 billion LINK. Chainlink follows a predictable annual release schedule of approximately The circulating supply of LINK currently stands at ~697M tokens, with a fixed total and maximum supply of 1 billion LINK. Chainlink follows a predictable annual release schedule of approximately 7% of total supply per year, which is relatively conservative compared to peer networks and largely aligned with industry best practices for long-dated token vesting. This emission rate is designed to gradually expand circulating supply while maintaining incentives for network participants. Treasury holdings remain modest relative to total supply, and importantly, major unlocks from early allocations have already occurred, reducing forward dilution risk. The remaining unlocks are largely programmatic and intended for long-term ecosystem growth rather than discretionary operational spending., which is relatively conservative compared to peer networks and largely aligned with industry best practices for long-dated token vesting.

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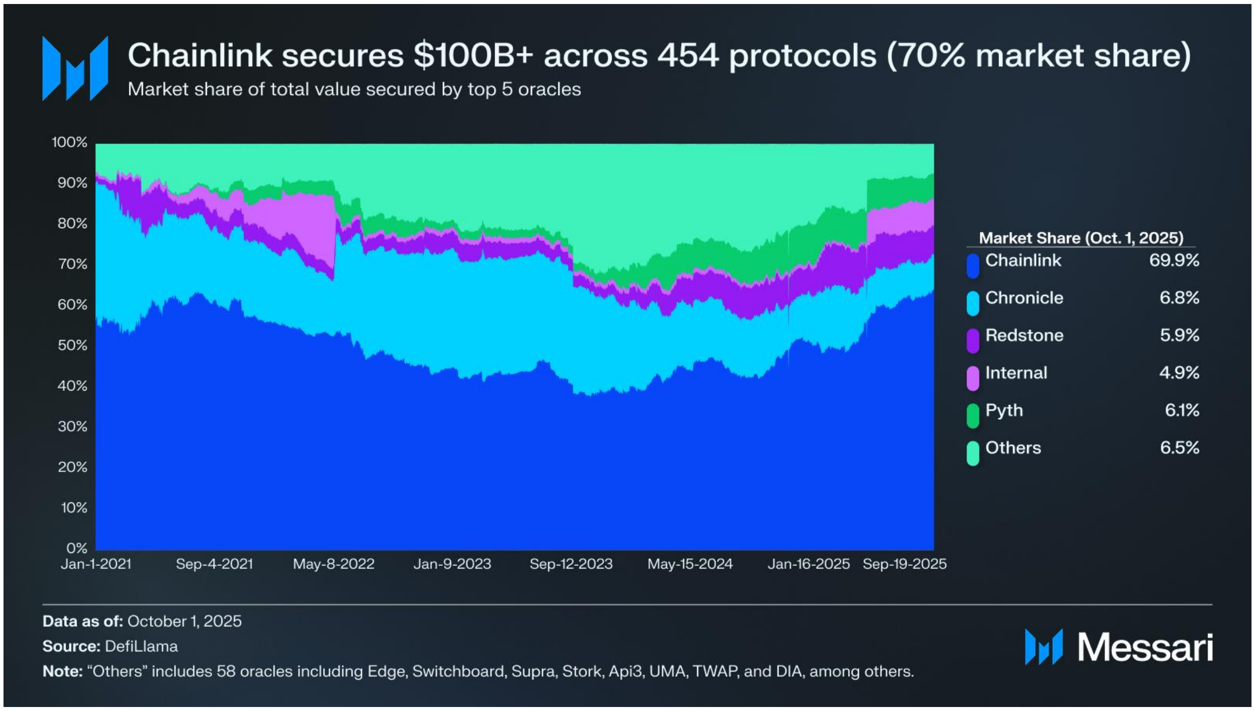

The broader tokenomics framework is reinforced by several complementary economic programs. Chainlink Build accelerates early-stage ecosystem growth by granting projects enhanced access to Chainlink services in exchange for 3–7% of their native token supply, distributed over time to LINK stakers and node operators. Chainlink Scale enables L1 and L2 ecosystems to subsidize oracle operating costs, supporting early developer adoption and reducing friction for new applications until user fees mature. Chainlink Rewards engages the broader community by enabling eligible stakers to claim token distributions from Build projects, enhancing ecosystem alignment and long-term participation.

Investment Thesis Fund Recommendation

We view Chainlink as one of the most compelling risk-adjusted bets in the infrastructure layer of crypto. It is already narrative focused in DeFi, secures the biggest protocols and stablecoin reserves, all while becoming the default connectivity layer for traditional finance through partnerships with Swift, Euroclear, large banks, and asset managers. Macro tailwinds are aligned with this positioning: the growth of tokenized RWAs and stablecoins, the need for cross-chain interoperability and proof-of-reserves, and an increasingly pro-crypto policy environment all point toward a future where onchain capital markets are mainstream—and where those markets depend on Chainlink's data, messaging, and compliance infrastructure.

At the token level, we believe $LINK at this current time is underperforming relative to this trajectory. The market largely values $LINK as a DeFi oracle token having supported the asset multiple times. Price is down roughly 50% from late 2024 highs despite clear fundamentals, increasingly clear regulation, and rising institutional integrations. Potential future ETF offerings provide further reason to see Chainlink as a protocol positioned to remain dominant for years to come. Given these network effects, improving tokenomics, and strong macro setup, we recommend a purchase of 3 ETH worth $LINK.

(Buy) for 3 $ETH of (Token, $LINK-) ***6 month – 1 year hold / Current Price Target: $30***

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